

England's social housing waiting-list outlook

What published register data suggests for 2026–2028, with a cautious planning view to 2030.

1,340,527	1,359,901	+1.4%
households on registers in 2025	full-history estimate for 2028	full-history change, 2025–2028

The central outlook

The evidence does not identify a robust national increase or decrease over the next three years. The damped-Holt model selected on the full 1987–2025 history gives a central estimate of **1,359,901 households in 2028 (+1.4%)**. However, naive performs better in both later-history sensitivity windows, especially 2005–2025.

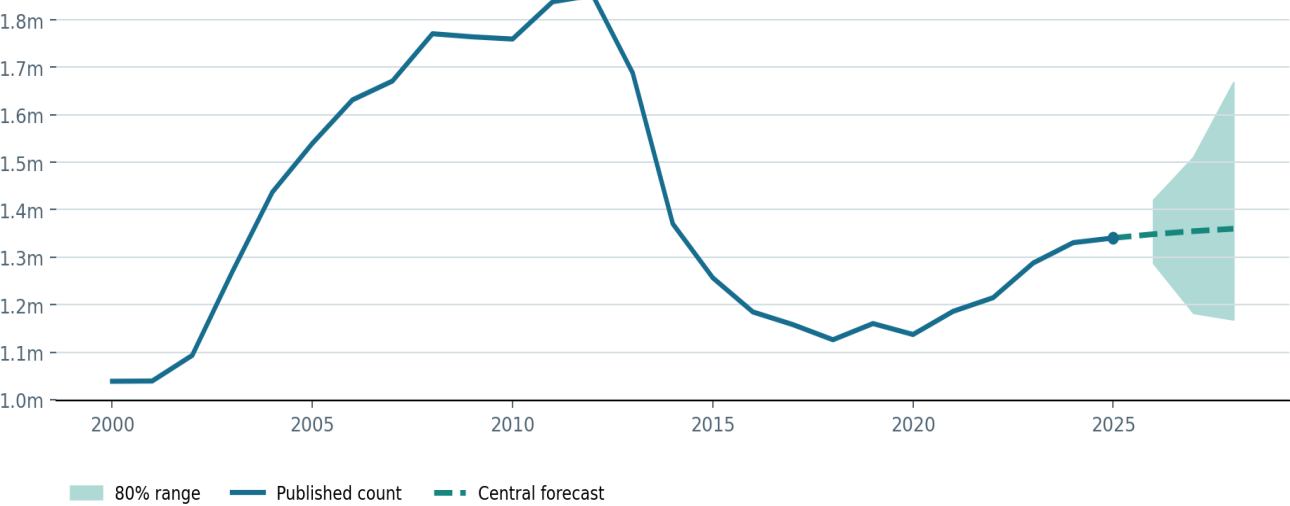
The uncertainty range is wide. For 2028, the empirical 80% range is approximately **1.17 million to 1.67 million**. Planning and public discussion should therefore focus on the range of plausible outcomes as well as the full-history central estimate.

Source: Ministry of Housing, Communities and Local Government Live Table 600. Counts are households on local-authority housing registers. The reference date is 1 April up to 2018 and 31 March from 2019 onward. Data retrieved 7 August 2026.

Waiting lists have moved in long cycles

The national series does not follow a simple straight line. It fell through much of the 1990s, rose strongly during the 2000s, peaked in 2012, then declined before increasing again after 2020.

England register counts and the 2026-2028 forecast



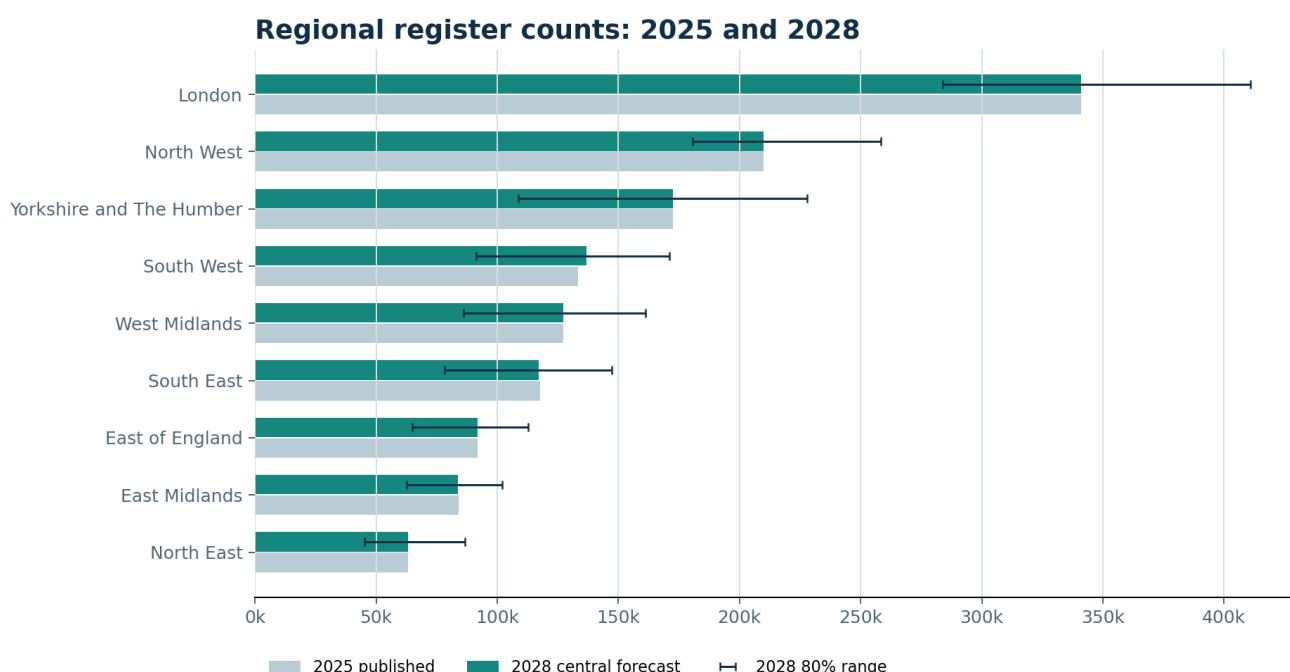
1.02m	1.85m	+17.9%
1998 series low	2012 series peak	increase from 2020 to 2025

Why this matters

Models that extend a fixed long-run trend can perform poorly when the underlying series has repeated turning points. The final forecast was therefore chosen through rolling historical tests rather than by selecting the model with the most visually compelling trajectory.

Regional backtests do not support a strong directional call

For six of nine regions, backtesting selected a naive model that carries the 2025 observation forward. The repeated 2028 central estimates are therefore properties of the selected models, not evidence that regional waiting lists will remain unchanged. The chart and table pair each central estimate with its 80% range.



Region	Selected model	2025	2028 central	2028 80% range
London	Naive	341,009	341,009	283,844–411,051
North West	Naive	209,887	209,887	180,532–258,491
Yorkshire and The Humber	Naive	172,536	172,536	108,697–227,863
South West	Drift	133,231	136,877	91,288–170,953
West Midlands	Naive	127,179	127,179	86,042–161,343
South East	Damped Holt trend	117,590	117,188	78,408–147,340
East of England	Naive	91,871	91,871	64,783–112,858
East Midlands	ARIMA	84,013	83,657	62,553–102,061
North East	Naive	63,211	63,211	45,228–86,552

A forecast is a range, not a promise

The central estimate summarises the model's expected path. The public 80% range shows how far historical forecast errors have extended when the same method was tested on unseen years.

Year	Central estimate	80% range
2026	1,348,467	1,288,128–1,420,408
2027	1,354,819	1,183,078–1,510,443
2028	1,359,901	1,169,171–1,667,851

What the 80% range shows

Uncertainty widens with time. The 2026 estimate is relatively concentrated, while the 2028 range is much broader. Outcomes near either side of the range would not automatically mean the model had failed; they reflect the volatility seen in the historical record.

Why a 95% range is not shown

Only 27 three-year backtest errors are available. Each 95% tail would therefore depend on roughly one extreme observation, including periods affected by identifiable changes in housing-register policy. Wider 95% figures remain in the technical report as diagnostic historical ranges, not stable probability limits.

What the range does not show

The range is based on historical model error. It cannot capture every possible policy change, administrative change or future shock. It should support scenario planning, not be read as an exact probability for every future event.

Communication principle

Headlines should pair the central estimate with its uncertainty. Reporting only 1.36 million would give a false impression of precision.

Built for transparent public use

The analysis uses a reproducible pipeline from the published source file to the dashboard, forecast tables and briefing. The final national and regional results can be regenerated from the repository.

Evidence step	What was done
Source integrity	The retained Table 600 workbook, extracts and processed series were compared directly.
Reconciliation	The nine regions sum exactly to England in every year from 1987 to 2025.
Model testing	Seven transparent models were evaluated with expanding-window rolling-origin backtesting. The ARIMA search collapses to the naive random walk and SES converges to $\alpha \approx 1$ on this series, so those rows are effectively equivalent baselines.
Selection	Mean absolute error was the primary measure because it is interpretable in households. Differences are descriptive; overlapping origins do not support formal claims of significance.
Uncertainty	Public 80% ranges were derived from out-of-sample historical errors; wider 95% diagnostics remain in the technical report.

Later-history sensitivity

Naive has lower mean Y1–Y3 MAE than the selected damped-Holt model in both later windows. This weakens the directional conclusion without changing the preserved full-history estimate.

History window	Damped-Holt mean MAE	Rank	Naive mean MAE	Winner
1998–2025	134,013	3 of 7	120,905	Naive
2005–2025	108,166	5 of 7	73,809	ARIMA

How the findings can be used

The dashboard supports national and regional comparison, planning conversations and accessible communication of uncertainty. The forecast provides an evidence baseline against which new data and policy developments can be assessed.

Measure and interpretation

Table 600 counts households on local-authority housing registers. Separate housing-association lists are not included; applicants can appear on more than one authority register, and the publisher says periodic reviews and duplicate listings mean the total is likely to overstate households still requiring social housing at any one time. These registers are therefore not a complete measure of housing need. Source-noted breaks include Telford & Wrekin leaving the register series from 31 March 2021 and Epping Forest changing transfer-applicant treatment from 2022–23; no re-modelling has been applied.

Accessible alternative: the repository's HTML analytical report provides the structured, screen-reader-friendly version of this briefing.